

Clause order

Subordinate clauses that start with relative pronouns always follow the noun or pronoun they are describing. If a subordinate clause starts with a subordinator or a participle, however, it can occupy different positions in a sentence.

▷ Ending a sentence

When a subordinate clause is placed at the end of a sentence, no comma is required to separate the clauses unless the sentence is long and would otherwise be confusing.

▷ Starting a sentence

If the subordinate clause is placed at the start of a sentence, however, it must be separated from the main clause that follows by a comma.

▷ Sitting in the middle

Similarly, if a subordinate clause breaks up a main clause, a comma is required at the start and end of the clause to separate it from the main clause.

The subordinate clause is separated from the main clause by a subordinator, so no comma is required.

Rob hid in a corner because he hated dancing.

This subordinate clause is at the beginning of the sentence, so a comma is required to separate the two clauses.

Until the class was over, Rob hid in a corner.

This subordinate clause has split the main clause into two parts, so commas are required to show which parts belong to which clauses.

Rob, feeling bored, hid in a corner.

Multiple subordinate clauses

As long as a complex sentence contains at least one main clause, more than one subordinate clause can be used. The easiest way to construct a complex sentence is to start with a main clause and then add the subordinate clauses, one at a time.

GLOSSARY

Main clause A group of words that contains a subject and a verb and makes complete sense on its own.

Relative pronoun A pronoun that links one part of a sentence to another by introducing a relative clause, which describes an earlier noun or pronoun.

Subject The person or thing that is performing the action of the verb.

Subordinate clause A group of words that contains a subject and a verb but depends on a main clause for its meaning.

Subordinator A conjunction used to connect words, phrases, and clauses of unequal importance.

A subordinate clause has been added to make this a complex sentence.

Tim missed the class.

main clause

**Although he loved dancing,
Tim missed the class.**

main clause

subordinate clause

**Although he loved dancing,
Tim missed the class,
which was full.**

main clause

A second subordinate clause has been added.